

Claude Code, from *zero*.

THE ONE-PAGE START

Claude Code turns plain English into working software, in your own project, on your own computer. **You do not need to know how to code.** You need to know what you want and how to check you got it. That is this sheet.

01

The first five minutes

```
npm install -g @anthropic-ai/claude-code
```

Once. Needs Node 18+ from nodejs.org.

```
cd my-project
```

It only sees the folder you start it in.

```
claude
```

That is the whole thing. Sign in when the browser opens.

```
/init
```

It writes itself a briefing on your project. Never skip.

Then ask it something you can check. Press **Esc** any time to stop it. You are never stuck.

02

The loop that actually works

- Explore.** Have it read the code and explain it back. End with "do not write any code yet".
- Plan.** Shift+Tab twice. It thinks, it cannot touch a file. Read the plan before approving it.
- Build.** One outcome per request. Small pieces, so you can tell which one broke.
- Prove.** Never accept "done". Ask for the real output or the loaded page.
- Save.** Say "commit this" every time it works. That is your undo button.

03

Three prompts that do the work

Type these in exactly. Replace anything in [BRACKETS]. Seventeen more on the full guide.

Explain my project to me

YOUR VERY FIRST REAL PROMPT IN ANY CODEBASE.

Read this project and explain it like I have never seen it: what it does, the five files that matter most, and the one thing most likely to break. No jargon, and do not write any code.

Plan it before you build it

EVERY FEATURE BIGGER THAN A TYPO.

I want to add [THE FEATURE]. Read the code that already does something similar, then give me a plan: the approach, every file you would change, and what could go wrong. Plan only, no code yet.

The error prompt

ANYTHING RED IN YOUR TERMINAL OR BROWSER CONSOLE.

[PASTE THE WHOLE ERROR] Reproduce this first. Then tell me the cause in one sentence. Then fix it and show me the run that proves it.

IF IT GOES SIDEWAYS

It changed files I never mentioned

Rewind, then name the file and the single outcome you want

It got slow and started making dumb mistakes

Clear the session and restate the goal in five lines

It is confidently wrong about a tool or library

Make it read the actual installed source, or run the tool with --help

04

Six rules we paid for

- Done is not evidence.** Load the real URL yourself. A green terminal is a claim.
- Never let it guess at a command.** Make it run `--help`. Invented options look exactly like real ones.
- Two failed attempts means the plan is wrong.** Stop patching. Back to plan mode, ask for another approach.
- Save at every working state.** "Commit this." Turns any disaster into a five second undo.
- Give it the error, all of it.** Paste every line. Your paraphrase deletes the part that solves it.
- One session, one job.** Two sessions on the same files overwrite each other quietly.



The command menu, always current for your version



Point at a file so it reads the right one



Save a rule to memory, permanently



Run a terminal command without leaving



The whole guide, free.

Seventeen prompts you can copy, the CLAUDE.md template, all twelve rules, and what to do when it goes sideways.

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